

Union Membership and White Racial Politics

Presented by Zahra Khan



Original Study

Abstract

“In this article, we investigate the role of union membership in shaping white racial attitudes. We draw upon research in history and American political development to generate a theory of interracial labor politics, in which union membership reduces racial resentment. Cross-sectional analyses consistently show that white union members have lower racial resentment and greater support for policies that benefit African Americans. More importantly, our panel analysis suggests that gaining union membership between 2010 and 2016 reduced racial resentment among white workers. “

Details of the Study

The authors develop a theory of labor unions and racial attitudes that predicts union membership reduces racial resentment towards African Americans rooted in historical realities. Throughout this study, the authors identified a gap in the literature that has focused on white labor politics, which has often been ignored through the lens of labor

The study uses data from CCES and VSG between 2010-2016, which the authors use both cross-sectional and panel data from the studies, which ask (1) "The Irish, Italians, Jews, and many other minorities overcame prejudice and worked their way up. Blacks should do the same without any special favors."

(2) "Generations of slavery and discrimination have created conditions that make it difficult for Blacks to work their way out of the lower class" (reverse coded).

(3) It's really a matter of some people not trying hard enough; if blacks would only try harder, they could be just as well off as whites.

(4) "Over the past few years, blacks have gotten less than they deserve" (reverse coded).

The authors run a standard OLS linear regression to examine the relationship between Racial Representative and Support for Affirmative Action Policy and Union Membership. The authors conduct analyses on both cross-sectional and panel data, while controlling for Age, Gender, Income, Education, and in the panel models, PartyID

My Contribution

- I chose to add an interaction term between age and union membership. Choosing this interaction term was rooted in historical realities. White union members have a complicated history with nativism and xenophobia that stretches from about 1845 to the 1990s. This encompasses white union members' role in passing legislation such as the 1924 Johnson-Reed Act and the Chinese Exclusion Act, as well as later legislation such as the 1986 Immigration Reform and Control Act directed towards Central American and Mexican Immigrants.
- However, labor unions have also, since the 1930s, been aligned with the Democratic Party and have, especially in times of need, aligned with marginalized groups. Therefore, I wanted to understand whether Union Membership would affect the relationship between age and racial resentment.

Table 1: Union Membership and Racial Resentment among Whites

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	Racial Resentment		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Union Member	-0.063*** (0.005)	-0.047*** (0.005)	-0.048*** (0.005)
Past Union Member	-0.020*** (0.003)	-0.024*** (0.003)	-0.025*** (0.003)
Female		-0.046*** (0.002)	-0.046*** (0.002)
Income		0.003*** (0.0004)	0.002*** (0.0004)
Age		0.0005*** (0.0001)	0.0005*** (0.0001)
Education		-0.049*** (0.001)	-0.050*** (0.001)
Constant	0.688*** (0.001)	0.946*** (0.012)	0.959*** (0.012)
State Fixed Effects	No	Yes	Yes
Year Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Observations	71,431	61,463	61,463
R ²	0.003	0.080	0.081
Adjusted R ²	0.003	0.079	0.080
Residual Std. Error	0.300 (df = 71428)	0.288 (df = 61406)	0.288 (df = 61405)
F Statistic	110.963*** (df = 2; 71428)	95.252*** (df = 56; 61406)	95.157*** (df = 57; 61405)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

- This is the original model in the study, which yields statistically significant results in which union membership decreased racial resentment. To proceed, I factored age and ran an interaction between the variable and union membership.

Table 6:

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	racial resentment		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
union member	-0.063*** (0.005)	-0.013 (0.018)	-0.014 (0.018)
past union member	-0.020*** (0.003)	-0.025*** (0.003)	-0.025*** (0.003)
Female		-0.046*** (0.002)	-0.045*** (0.002)
Income		0.002*** (0.0004)	0.002*** (0.0004)
age 31-50		0.059*** (0.005)	0.057*** (0.005)
age 51-70		0.052*** (0.004)	0.051*** (0.004)
age_binned 70+		0.042*** (0.005)	0.042*** (0.005)
Education		-0.049*** (0.001)	-0.049*** (0.001)
union member: age 31-50		-0.004 (0.020)	-0.003 (0.020)
union member: age 51-70		-0.051*** (0.019)	-0.050*** (0.019)
union member:age 70+		-0.083*** (0.026)	-0.082*** (0.026)
Constant	0.688*** (0.001)	0.926*** (0.012)	0.940*** (0.012)
State Fixed Effects	No	Yes	Yes
Year Fixed Effects	No	No	Yes
Observations	71,431	61,463	61,463
R ²	0.003	0.083	0.084
Adjusted R ²	0.003	0.082	0.083
Residual Std. Error	0.300 (df = 71428)	0.288 (df = 61401)	0.287 (df = 61400)
F Statistic	110.963*** (df = 2; 71428)	90.771*** (df = 61; 61401)	90.471*** (df = 62; 61400)

- For younger members, union membership has no significant effect on racial resentment. However, for members ages 51-70, the term indicates that union membership almost completely cancels out the effect of age on racial resentment. Further, for those over the age of seventy, union membership pushes them below the baseline

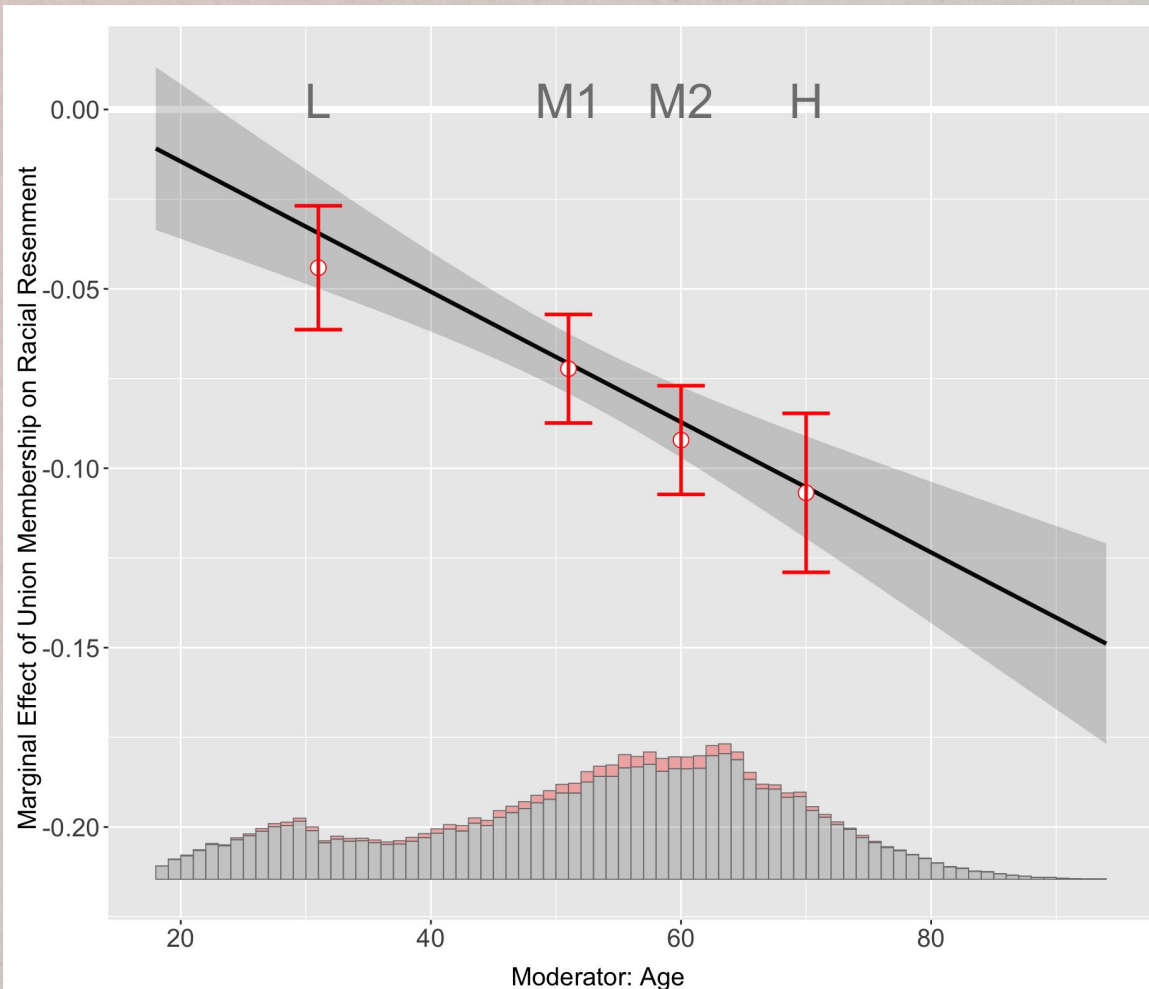


Table 5: CCES Panel Results of Union Membership and Racial Resentment among Whites

	Outcome: Racial Resentment			
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4
Gained Union Membership	-0.055*** (0.018)	-0.055*** (0.018)	-0.051*** (0.019)	-0.049*** (0.018)
Lost Union Membership	0.0002 (0.032)	-0.00001 (0.032)	-0.003 (0.033)	0.009 (0.033)
Racial Resentment (t-1)	0.899*** (0.005)	0.899*** (0.005)	0.884*** (0.005)	0.797*** (0.007)
Party ID (Democratic)				-0.124*** (0.005)
Income			0.0004 (0.001)	-0.0005 (0.001)
Female			-0.007* (0.003)	0.002 (0.003)
Age			0.0003** (0.0001)	0.0002 (0.0001)
Education			-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)
Constant	0.056*** (0.004)	0.054*** (0.004)	0.084*** (0.012)	0.215*** (0.014)
Year Fixed Effects	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	10908	10908	9726	9617
R-squared	0.749	0.749	0.749	0.764
Adj. R-squared	0.749	0.749	0.749	0.764
Residual Std. Error	0.165 (df = 10904)	0.165 (df = 10903)	0.165 (df = 9717)	0.161 (df = 9607)
F Statistic	10863.440*** (df = 3; 10904)	8148.794*** (df = 4; 10903)	3629.656*** (df = 8; 9717)	3454.658*** (df = 9; 9607)

***p < .01; **p < .05; *p < .1

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1 lm_1 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag, data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
2 lm_2 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag + factor(year), data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
3 lm_3 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag + faminc_10 + factor(gender_10) + age_10 + educ_10 + factor(year), data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
4 lm_4 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag + dem_id_2010 + faminc_10 + factor(gender_10) + age_10 + educ_10 + factor(year), data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
```

- This is the original model in the study, which yields statistically significant results for union membership and racial resentment. However, it was not a statistically significant variable, unlike in all of the cross-sectional models. Most likely an indication of a lack of within-person variation across the panel.

Interaction Term

My findings

	racial_resentment			
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4
union_gained	-0.055*** (0.018)	-0.055*** (0.018)	-0.048* (0.028)	-0.041 (0.028)
union_lost	0.0002 (0.032)	-0.00001 (0.032)	-0.004 (0.033)	0.008 (0.033)
racial_resentment_lag	0.899*** (0.005)	0.899*** (0.005)	0.884*** (0.006)	0.795*** (0.007)
dem_id_2010				-0.125*** (0.006)
famine_10			0.0004 (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)
factor(gender_10)1			-0.007** (0.004)	0.002 (0.003)
age_factor(g)[60,80]			-0.005 (0.004)	-0.004 (0.004)
age_factor(g)[80,100]			0.004 (0.007)	-0.005 (0.007)
educ_10			-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)
union_gained:age_factor(g)[60,80]			-0.007 (0.040)	-0.007 (0.039)
union_gained:age_factor(g)[80,100]			-0.003 (0.167)	-0.0003 (0.162)
Constant	0.056*** (0.004)	0.054*** (0.004)	0.108*** (0.009)	0.234*** (0.010)
Year Fixed Effects	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	10908	10908	9333	9228
R-squared	0.749	0.749	0.750	0.765
Adj. R-squared	0.749	0.749	0.749	0.765
Residual Std. Error	0.165 (df = 10904)	0.165 (df = 10903)	0.164 (df = 9321)	0.160 (df = 9215)
F Statistic	10863.440*** (df = 3; 10904)	8148.794*** (df = 4; 10903)	2539.181*** (df = 11; 9321)	2497.975*** (df = 12; 9215)

***p < .01; **p < .05; *p < .1

```
1 lm.1 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag, data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
2 lm.2 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag + factor(year), data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
3 lm.3 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag + famine_10 + factor(gender_10) + age_factor + educ_10 + factor(year) + union_gained*age_factor, data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
4 lm.4 <- lm(racial_resentment ~ union_gained + union_lost + racial_resentment_lag + dem_id_2010 + famine_10 + factor(gender_10) + age_factor + educ_10 + factor(year) + union_gained*age_factor, data_long[data_long$race_10==1,])
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- After running the model with the interaction terms, I found that, in addition to age not being statistically significant, the interaction term between Union Membership and Racial Resentment is also not statistically significant. A possible reason for the lack of significance could be that, as respondents age, their opinions do not change meaningfully; the within-person variation attributable to aging over time is either very small or null in 2010 and 2014.